The Lantern Keeper

Every evening, just before the sun slipped behind the hills, old Mr. Hale climbed the stone steps of the lighthouse at Gull Point. He carried a brass lantern in one hand and a tin of matches in the other, and he counted the steps aloud as he went. There were one hundred and twelve of them. He had never once counted wrong.

Nora watched him from the bottom of the stairs. She was eleven years old, and she had come to live with her grandfather at the beginning of the summer, when her mother took a job in the city. At first the lighthouse had seemed lonely and enormous. Now it felt like a castle that belonged to the two of them.

“Why do you count?” she asked one evening.

“So that I always know where I am,” said Mr. Hale. “On a dark night, a man can lose his way even on his own staircase.”

“But you have the lantern.”

“A lantern shows you the next step,” he said. “Counting tells you how far you have come.”

Nora thought about that for a long time. She thought about it while she dried the supper dishes, and while she listened to the waves pulling at the rocks below the window, and while she lay awake under the heavy wool blanket that smelled faintly of salt.

In August a storm arrived. It came quickly, the way storms sometimes do at the edge of the sea, with a wind that rattled the shutters and a rain that fell sideways. Mr. Hale had gone to the village that afternoon to buy oil and bread, and he had not come back.

Nora stood at the kitchen window and waited. The clock on the shelf ticked past six, then seven. The sky turned the color of a bruise. Somewhere